# Eight tenses: the present.

Four viewpoints: routine, activity now, result by now, and process up to now.

## Present Simple

Routines, general facts, and states.

**+** I/you/we/they work; he/she works
**-** do/does not + base verb
**?** Do/Does + subject + base verb?

**Common clues:** usually, often, every day, sometimes, never

**Example:** She usually works at home.

Does she work? Not: does she works. With be: am/is/are; Is she ready?

## Present Continuous

An activity now, a temporary situation, or a change.

**+** am/is/are + verb-ing
**-** am/is/are not + verb-ing
**?** Am/Is/Are + subject + verb-ing?

**Common clues:** now, right now, at the moment, this week

**Example:** I am working in the office this week.

A temporary meaning matters more than the time phrase. Know normally describes a state.

## Present Perfect Simple

A result, experience, or unfinished state linked to now.

**+** have/has + past participle (V3)
**-** have/has not + V3
**?** Have/Has + subject + V3?

**Common clues:** already, just, yet, ever, never, so far; for/since with states

**Example:** I have already sent three emails.

I have known her for years. Do not use this tense with a finished time such as yesterday.

## Present Perfect Continuous

An ongoing or recent activity; focus on process or duration up to now.

**+** have/has been + verb-ing
**-** have/has not been + verb-ing
**?** Have/Has + subject + been + verb-ing?

**Common clues:** for, since, all morning, lately, how long

**Example:** I have been studying for two hours.

The activity may have just stopped. I have been studying explains why I need a break.

## Small words, big differences.

**Already / just** usually go between have/has and V3. **Yet** usually goes at the end of a question or negative.
**For** = a length of time; **since** = a starting point. Both can occur with simple or continuous perfect forms.
**Now:** I am working now (activity), but I know the answer now (state).

**Reference:** British Council: already, just and yet and Present Perfect.

# Eight tenses: the past.

Start with a past viewpoint. Then ask: event, background, earlier result, or earlier process?

## Past Simple

A finished event, sequence, habit, or state in the past.

**+** regular verb-ed / irregular past form
**-** did not + base verb
**?** Did + subject + base verb?

**Common clues:** yesterday, last week, ago, in 2020, then

**Example:** I opened the file and checked the title.

Did she go? Not: did she went. With be: was/were; Was she ready?

## Past Continuous

An activity underway at a past moment; background to an event.

**+** was/were + verb-ing
**-** was/were not + verb-ing
**?** Was/Were + subject + verb-ing?

**Common clues:** at eight yesterday, while, when (with a past event)

**Example:** I was cooking when the doorbell rang.

Was cooking gives the background; rang introduces the event. While/when are clues, not rules.

## Past Perfect Simple

An earlier completed result or state, viewed from a later past moment.

**+** had + past participle (V3)
**-** had not + V3
**?** Had + subject + V3?

**Common clues:** already, just, never; by then, before, by the time

**Example:** When I arrived, she had already left.

The departure came first. After can make an order clear without making Past Perfect compulsory.

## Past Perfect Continuous

An earlier process or duration up to a past moment; often explains a result.

**+** had been + verb-ing
**-** had not been + verb-ing
**?** Had + subject + been + verb-ing?

**Common clues:** for, since, all day; before, when, by the time

**Example:** I was tired because I had been working for hours.

The activity may have just stopped. Use had known, not had been knowing, for a state.

### Compare the same past viewpoint.

**At six, I was writing.** The activity was underway.
**By six, I had written three pages.** Three completed pages.
**By six, I had been writing for two hours.** Duration, with no guarantee that the work was finished.
**Already** can appear with different tenses: the surrounding timeline decides.

**Reference:** British Council: Past Perfect. Examples and comparisons written for this guide.